

A local politician, his crookery dripping from his excessively waxed moustache, makes the mistake of mentioning the word *naach gaana* to the just-in-from New York Madhuri Dixit. The diva fixes him with a raised eyebrow, a charming smile and a sweeping hand gesture, a supremely coordinated movement that only she can effect, and says, *nritya aur sangeet kahiye*.

Five years away have only accentuated what was obvious when she pitted her formidable talent with the supremely beautiful Aishwarya Rai in her last film, *Devdas*. This is a woman who has lived a life, not just inhabited a bubble. She may find the task of running up and down the stairs of her 7,000 sq-ft home in Denver part of the normal routine of being a suburban mom to two young children and wife to successful cardiothoracic surgeon, but it has sharpened her appetite for acting. So though she looks every one of 42 years, she has never been in better shape.

Aaja Nachle, the last in writer Jaideep Sahni's trilogy of small town winners (*Bunty Aur Babli* in 2005 and *Chak De* earlier this year being the first two), is a movie that plays on the themes he knows best. Small town underdog takes on big city guile, is pitted against a foreign-educated MP and a cynical builder who wants to destroy an open-air auditorium to erect a mall, the ultimate symbol of wasteful urban distraction. As an idea it seems to have big bucks sown into its seam but it all begins to



film review

The Dixie Chick

AJAJ NACHLE

Director: Anil Mehta

Starring: Madhuri Dixit, Kunal Kapoor and Konkona Sen Sharma



ODD COUPLE: Kunal Kapoor and Konkona Sen Sharma

come apart fairly soon.

It's a pity because no-one can be impervious to Dixit's naughty charm, her adrenaline pumping energy, and rather forward ways (she thinks nothing of winking jauntily at the local tough in whom she

sees the perfect loverboy for the *Laila Majnu* musical she intends to stage). Whether she is announcing her musical from a gaily-painted cycle rickshaw or breaking the local tea shop vendor's heart into a million little

pieces, Dixit is electric. But her milieu is as fake as the *Aaja Nachle* set on a Film City lot. Sahni is a talented writer, but here his creations don't have enough heart-warming moments to allow us to feel for them. Except of course for Dixit. Whether it is her short fly-away hair ("we thought that's how someone who lives abroad would cut their hair given the hassle of washing and drying", says Dixit) or her stern eyeballing of her NRI daughter who asks whether the water is safe to drink ("that's typical, isn't it," says Dixit), there's no false note. And when she dances, as Shiamak Davar has said, she does so with her soul.

Dixit is living the dream of anonymity that she has craved for long. "In India, I would just have to say *chai* and it would materialise in front of me," she laughs, "there, even if it's a faulty flush I have to get it fixed myself." The woman who has been seducing the camera since she was 16, seems to have fitted into her new role with ease. She can gush about watching a heart transplant in action as warmly as she speaks about playing referee when her two boys (two and four) start squabbling.

Aaja Nachle is worth watching just to remind oneself of what a real woman can look like in a sea of pneumatic dolls. Welcome back, Dixie, and may Bollywood find it in its masculine heart to make films worthy of you.

by Kaveri Bamzai